



Acts 8:1-8 “Great Persecution, Great Lamentation, Great Joy”

Intro:

Throughout His ministry, Jesus repeatedly taught His disciples to expect persecution (John 15:18–20; John 16:1–4; Matthew 10:16–18; Luke 21:16–19). If they persecuted the Master, they would also persecute His servants. Jesus prepared them for this so that when persecution came, they would not be discouraged or caught by surprise, but would remain faithful to the mission He had given them. As we enter Acts 8, that persecution has arrived in full force. Stephen has been killed, Saul is ravaging the church, and believers are being scattered from Jerusalem. Yet rather than stopping the Gospel, God uses the persecution to push His people outward and fulfill the words of Jesus in Acts 1:8: *“You will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth.”* And what is important for us to notice is how these disciples respond. They scatter, but they do not abandon the mission. They continue preaching the Word. Luke then brings our attention to one of them, Philip, and through his story we see that even in the midst of *great persecution and great lamentation, God can bring great joy as His people remain kingdom-minded and on mission, remembering that the purpose of our lives is to preach Jesus.*

V.1-3

“And Saul approved of his execution. And there arose on that day a great persecution against the church in Jerusalem, and they were all scattered throughout the regions of Judea and Samaria, except the apostles. Devout men buried Stephen and made great lamentation over him. But Saul was ravaging the church, and entering house after house, he dragged off men and women and committed them to prison.”

1. Great Persecution

Last week we got our first glimpse of one of the main figures in the book of Acts: Saul, later known as Paul. His story begins with those who stoned Stephen laying their garments at his feet, seemingly recognizing his authority and approval over what was taking place. And chapter 8 makes that approval explicit: *“Saul approved of his execution.”* From this point forward, Saul takes a leading role in the persecution of the church, ravaging it, entering house after house, and dragging believers off to prison. But we need to notice what brought this persecution upon the church: **the preaching of the Gospel**. Stephen had faithfully proclaimed Christ, and the response of those who rejected that message was hatred and persecution. But this should not have surprised the disciples because Jesus had already prepared them for it. He told them, *“If they persecuted me, they will also persecute you”* (John 15:20).

Persecution, then, is something the faithful Christian should expect. We may not experience it in the same violent form these believers did, but whenever we faithfully stand upon the truth of God's Word and proclaim Christ, we should not be surprised when there is opposition. The world that rejected Christ will also oppose the message of Christ. This does not mean that we should seek persecution, create unnecessary conflict, or treat opposition as if it were something noble in itself. But neither should we fear it so much that we compromise the truth or become ashamed to preach Christ. *We do not seek persecution, but we should expect it; and when it comes because of our faithfulness to Christ, we must not allow it to silence us.*

2. Great Lamentation

In the middle of this great persecution, Luke gives us a small but beautiful detail: *“Devout men buried Stephen and made great lamentation over him.”* While Saul and others are violently opposing the church, there are still devout men who honor Stephen and mourn his death. Sometimes, when evil seems to surround us, it can feel as though we are the only ones left seeking to remain faithful to God. Elijah once felt this way, saying, *“I, even I only, am left”* (1 Kings 19:10). Yet God reminded him that He had preserved seven thousand in Israel who had not bowed to Baal (1 Kings 19:18). *No matter how dark things appear, God has not lost control. He continues saving, preserving, and sustaining those who belong to Him.* But notice also that these believers lamented. They knew where Stephen was. They knew he belonged to Christ. They knew that death could not separate him from his Savior. And yet they still mourned deeply because losing someone we love genuinely hurts.

True hope does not require us to pretend that suffering is painless. Scripture does not tell us not to grieve; it tells us that we do not *“grieve as others do who have no hope”* (1 Thessalonians 4:13). We can experience great lamentation while still possessing great hope. For the believer, death is not the end. The separation is real and painful, but it is temporary.

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And the same is true more broadly when suffering and persecution come. *We do not have to deny the pain in order to trust God through it.* There may be great lamentation, but lamentation does not mean hopelessness. Christ has promised to be with His people to the end of the age, and He has already told us, *"In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world"* (John 16:33). The question, then, is not whether difficult seasons will hurt. **The question is what we will do in the midst of that hurt.**

V.4-8

"Now **those who were scattered went about preaching the word.** *Philip went down to the city of Samaria and proclaimed to them the Christ.* And the crowds with one accord **paid attention** to what was being said by Philip, when they *heard* him and *saw* the signs that he did. For unclean spirits, crying out with a loud voice, came out of many who had them, and many who were paralyzed or lame were healed. **So there was much joy in that city.**"

3. Great Joy

And that brings us to verse 4: *"Now those who were scattered went about preaching the word."* That verse is the turning point of this passage. There was **great persecution**. There was **great lamentation**. But neither one silenced the church. They were scattered, but wherever they went, *they preached the Word*. In fact, the very persecution intended to stop the Gospel became an instrument God used to spread it. Jesus had told His disciples in Acts 1:8 that they would be His witnesses *"in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."* Until this point, the church had largely remained in Jerusalem. But now persecution scatters them into Judea and Samaria. What their enemies intended to suppress, God sovereignly used to advance.

This is a beautiful example of the truth of Romans 8:28: *"For those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose."* The persecution was evil. Stephen's murder was evil. God did not need to call evil good in order to sovereignly use even their evil actions to accomplish His good purposes. *The persecution that was meant to silence the Gospel became the means through which the Gospel spread.* Luke then gives us one example of these scattered believers: Philip. This is not Philip the apostle, but Philip from Acts 6, one of the seven men chosen alongside Stephen. Think about what that means. Stephen had served beside him and had just been stoned for preaching Christ. Philip had every earthly reason to be afraid. Yet when persecution scattered him to Samaria, what did he do? *"Philip went down to the city of Samaria and proclaimed to them the Christ."* Philip did not allow persecution to make him silent or lamentation to make him lose sight of his mission. Wherever God's sovereignty placed him, he preached Christ. And God used his faithfulness to bring the Gospel to Samaria. People heard, people believed, lives were changed, and verse 8 gives us the result: *"So there was much joy in that city."*

Conclusion and Main Idea:

That is the beautiful progression of this passage: **Great persecution. Great lamentation. And yet, great joy.** The persecution did not disappear. The pain of losing Stephen was still real. What changed was not necessarily their circumstances, but how God's people responded within them. They remained kingdom-minded. They remained on mission. They continued preaching Christ. And the same must be true of us. We do not know what persecution, rejection, loss, or lamentation faithfulness to Christ may bring. But none of those things change our mission. **Wherever God's sovereignty places us, we are called to preach Christ.** If fear or shame silences us, we lose sight of the mission Christ has given us. But when, even through persecution and lamentation, we continue faithfully preaching the Word, we get to experience the joy of seeing God accomplish His purposes through the Gospel. **The first fruit of salvation is joy.** Philip preached Christ, people received Christ, and an entire city was filled with joy. The world may bring persecution and suffering, but it cannot take away the joy found in Christ.

Memory Verse:

"Now those who were scattered went about preaching the word. Acts 8:4

